Lesson 01: Writing Basics Review: Sentences, Pronouns, Adjectives and Adverbs

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 1: Refining Sentences and Punctuation

Adapted from College ESL Writers: Applied Grammar and Composing Strategies for Success by Barbara Hall and Elizabeth Wallace, Georgia State University - Perimeter College (CC BY-NC-SA): 1.1: Sentence Writing; 1.2: Sentence Structure; 1.3: Pronouns; 1.4: Adjectives and Adverbs; 1.5: Writing basics (Exercise).

In this lesson

This lesson is a fast review of what makes a good sentence: a subject, a verb and a complete idea, built on six basic patterns, with pronouns, adjectives and adverbs that match and describe the right words. You studied most of these points at B2, so here you work like an editor: you analyse sentences, check agreement and repair a paragraph with fragments and run-ons. The rest of Unit 1 builds on these checks.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Identify the subject, the type of verb (action, linking or helping) and the basic pattern of a sentence.
- Check that pronouns agree with their antecedents, including indefinite pronouns and collective nouns.
- Choose correct subject, object and relative pronouns.
- Decide whether a word is an adjective or an adverb by what it describes.
- Find and correct fragments and run-ons in a paragraph.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
independent clause	a group of words with a subject and a verb that can stand alone as a complete thought	Huxley uses satire.
compound subject	two or more nouns or pronouns that form the subject together	Ansam and Sherry have been best friends.
prepositional phrase	a preposition + a noun or pronoun; it is never the subject	Near them, the children played.
action verb	a verb that shows what the subject is doing	Francois sings horribly.
linking verb	a verb that connects the subject to a describing word	She looks beautiful.
helping verb	a form of be, do or have, or a word like can or would, used with the main verb for tense or mood	… so I did not see him until Monday at work.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
direct object (DO)	the noun or pronoun that receives the action of the verb	Barbara moved it to the corner.
indirect object (IO)	the person or thing to whom the action is done; it comes before the DO	I told her we had meetings ...
antecedent	the word or words a pronoun refers back to	Lani complained that she was exhausted. (Lani is the antecedent of she.)
indefinite pronoun	a pronoun that does not refer to a specific person or thing	Everyone is kept "happy" in the brave new world ...
collective noun	a noun for a group, usually treated as singular	audience, committee, government, jury, team
relative pronoun	who, whom, whose, which or that; it connects details to a noun	... satire, which is a type of humor ...
adjective / adverb	a word that describes a noun or pronoun / a verb, an adjective or another adverb	My sociology instructor is extremely wise.

Rules and explanations

1. The parts of a complete sentence

A complete sentence (an independent clause) needs a **subject**, a **verb** and a **complete idea**: it must make sense on its own.

- **Subject:** who or what the sentence is about, usually at the beginning: a noun (a person, place, thing or idea) or a pronoun. A compound subject has more than one.
- A **prepositional phrase** is never the subject. In long academic sentences, set the phrases aside to find the real subject: in "The humans in Brave New World learn through sleep teaching", the subject is *the humans*, so the verb is *learn*.
- **Verbs:** an **action verb** shows what the subject is doing ("Francois sings horribly"); a **linking verb** connects the subject to a describing word ("She looks beautiful"); a **helping verb** (a form of be, do or have; also can and similar words such as would) is used with the main verb to show tense or mood ("I did not see him"). A few verbs can be either action or linking verbs, with different meanings: an action, or how the subject appears.
- The book's editing questions: *Who or what is the sentence about? Which word shows an action or links the subject to a description?*

2. Six basic sentence patterns

Longer sentences are built on these patterns by adding other parts of speech. When an academic sentence is hard to check, find its core pattern first. The book's examples in 1.1 and 1.2 are pictures that are not in your printed material, so the examples below come from other parts of the book. Brackets show extra phrases.

Pattern	Example
Subject–Verb	My mother stood (between us).
Subject–Linking Verb–Noun	My favorite book is Brave New World.
Subject–Linking Verb–Adjective	(For both students and professionals,) clear communication is important.
Subject–Verb–Adverb	Francois sings horribly.
Subject–Verb–Direct Object	She loves the Blue Ridge Mountains (in the fall).
Subject–Verb–Indirect Object–Direct Object	I told her (IO) we had meetings until our flight took off (DO).

The direct object receives the action of the verb. The indirect object says to whom or to what the action is done and comes before the direct object, which can be a whole clause, as in the last example (from section 2.3 of the book).

3. Pronouns

- A pronoun agrees with its **antecedent** in **number** (singular or plural) and **person** (I/we, you, he/she/it/they).
- **Indefinite pronouns** (everyone, each, nobody, someone …) are usually singular, so a verb or pronoun that refers to them is singular too: "Everyone *is* kept 'happy' …". To be precise about the book's list: both, few, many, several and others are always plural; all, any, none and some can be singular or plural, depending on the noun they refer to.
- **Collective nouns** (audience, faculty, public, class, government, society, company, band, family, school, committee, group, team, jury) suggest more than one person but are usually singular: use a singular verb and *it/its*.
- **Subject or object?** Object pronouns are objects of a verb ("Marie leaned over and kissed *him*") or of a preposition ("My mother stood between *us*"); they are never subjects. To test a compound subject, remove the other subject: "me visited the Grand Canyon last summer" sounds wrong at once, so the correct pronoun is *I*.
- **Relative pronouns** connect details to a noun and can combine two sentences. *Who, whom* and *whose* refer only to people, *which* to things, and *that* to people or things: "satire, *which* is a type of humor *that* is used to make a serious point".

> **In psychology papers:** The book asks for a singular pronoun after a singular antecedent such as *everyone*. APA style (7th edition), the style used in psychology, endorses singular *they* for a person whose gender is unknown or not relevant, instead of *he or she*.

4. Adjectives and adverbs

- An **adjective** describes a noun or pronoun and answers *which one? what kind? how many?* ("The green sweater belongs to Iris.")

- An **adverb** describes a verb, an adjective or another adverb and answers *how? to what extent? why? when? where?* ("Francois sings horribly." "My sociology instructor is extremely wise." "He threw the ball very accurately.") Most adverbs are adjective + -ly.
- After a linking verb, use an adjective, because it describes the subject, not an action: "She looks beautiful."
- Comparatives compare two persons or things; superlatives compare more than two. Note the special forms: good, better, best; well, better, best; bad, worse, worst; badly, worse, worst.

> **Note for Arabic speakers**
>
> - An Arabic sentence in the present tense often has no verb "be". In English, the linking verb is always needed: "My sociology instructor is extremely wise", never "My sociology instructor extremely wise".
> - Arabic can repeat a subject or object with a pronoun. English does not: "Huxley uses satire" (not "Huxley he uses satire"); "the novel that I read" (not "that I read it").

Practice

1. Sentence parts. For each sentence from the lesson material, name the subject, the verb or verbs with their type (action, linking, helping), and the basic pattern.

1. Near them, the children played.
2. Huxley uses satire.
3. Without them, your language would be very boring.
4. Ansam and Sherry have been best friends.
5. The humans in Brave New World learn through sleep teaching.
6. Most likely, this book would frustrate and confuse you.
7. Barbara moved it to the corner.
8. Every summer, they picked up litter from national parks.

2. Adjective or adverb? Is each word in bold an adjective or an adverb? Which word does it describe?

1. Hieu left the party **early**.
2. This may not seem like a **humorous** premise for a novel.
3. The subject **usually** appears at the beginning of a sentence.
4. Without **clear** and **concise** sentences, it is **difficult** to find the information you need.
5. Lani complained that she was **exhausted**.
6. Pronouns are **very important** to your writing and speaking.

3. Writing basics (lesson material, 1.5). Number the blanks in the Brave New World paragraph 1 to 10.

- a. Identify each sentence as a fragment, a run-on, or correct (no error).

- b. Rewrite the paragraph, correcting the fragments and run-ons. Use several methods: a period, a comma + and/but, a dependent word such as because, a relative pronoun, an -ed phrase.

4. Pronouns in the same paragraph. "Sentence 5" means the sentence that ends at blank 5. Find the antecedent of each pronoun.

1. he (sentence 1)
2. which (sentence 4)
3. this (sentence 5)
4. who (sentence 6)
5. he (sentence 7)
6. it (sentence 10)
7. *Everyone* in sentence 6 is an indefinite pronoun. Which word shows that it is singular?
8. Which two relative pronouns in sentence 4 refer to things? Could *who* replace either of them?

Speak with your tutor

- "Give me ten sentences from an introductory psychology textbook. I will name the subject, the verb type and the pattern of each. Then check my analysis."
- "Here is my rewrite of the Brave New World paragraph: [paste]. Did I fix every fragment and run-on? Is there a better way to join any of the sentences?"
- "Test me on agreement: give me eight sentences with a blank for a verb or pronoun after an indefinite pronoun or a collective noun."
- "Here is a paragraph from my PSYC 110 notes: [paste]. Mark every pronoun whose antecedent is unclear or does not agree, but let me correct them."

Writing task

Write a paragraph of 150 to 200 words that recommends a book, like the Brave New World paragraph. Choose a novel or non-fiction book you admire, or a psychology book or textbook chapter you have read for PSYC 110 (for example, on memory or on sleep and dreams). Give the title and author in the first sentence, then a short description of the content, one reason why the book matters, and a final recommendation. Use at least four of the six basic patterns and at least two relative pronouns.

Self-editing checklist:

- Every sentence has a subject, a verb and a complete idea (no fragments).
- No two independent clauses are joined with only a comma or with nothing (no run-ons).
- Every pronoun has a clear antecedent and agrees with it.
- Indefinite pronouns and collective nouns have the correct verb and pronoun.
- Object pronouns are never subjects.
- *Who, whom* and *whose* refer to people, *which* to things, *that* to either.
- Adjectives follow linking verbs; adverbs describe verbs, adjectives and other adverbs.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

1. (S = subject, V = verb)

1. S: the children; V: played (action). Subject–Verb. (*Near them* is a prepositional phrase.)
2. S: Huxley; V: uses (action); DO: satire. Subject–Verb–Direct Object.
3. S: your language; V: would (helping) + be (linking); *boring* is an adjective. Subject–Linking Verb–Adjective.
4. S: Ansam and Sherry (compound); V: have (helping) + been (linking); *best friends* is a noun phrase. Subject–Linking Verb–Noun.
5. S: The humans; V: learn (action). Subject–Verb. (*in Brave New World* and *through sleep teaching* are prepositional phrases.)
6. S: this book; V: would (helping) + frustrate and confuse (action); DO: you. Subject–Verb–Direct Object.
7. S: Barbara; V: moved (action); DO: it. Subject–Verb–Direct Object (+ *to the corner*).
8. S: they; V: picked up (action); DO: litter. Subject–Verb–Direct Object (+ *Every summer*, *from national parks*).

2.

1. adverb; describes the verb *left* (when?).
2. adjective; describes the noun *premise*.
3. adverb; describes the verb *appears* (how often?).
4. *clear*, *concise*: adjectives describing *sentences*; *difficult*: adjective after the linking verb *is*, describing *it* (finding the information).
5. adjective after the linking verb *was*; describes *she*.
6. *very*: adverb describing the adjective *important*; *important*: adjective after *are*, describing *Pronouns*.

3.

- a. 1 run-on (comma splice); 2 fragment; 3 fragment; 4 correct; 5 run-on (comma splice); 6 run-on (comma splice); 7 fragment; 8 correct; 9 run-on (comma splice); 10 run-on (comma splice). (The book's "run-on" covers fused sentences and comma splices. Sentences 2 and 3 have no main verb; sentence 7 is a *because* clause with no main clause.)
- b. (example answer) My favorite book is Brave New World by Aldous Huxley, who was born in 1894 and died in 1963. Written in 1931, the novel describes a futuristic society where humans are born out of test tubes and kept in rigid social classes. This may not seem like a humorous premise for a novel, but Huxley uses satire, which is a type of humor that is used to make a serious point. The humans in Brave New World learn through sleep teaching; Huxley calls this "hypnopedia." Everyone is kept "happy" in the brave new world by taking a pill called soma. However, there is one character, John the Savage, who does not take soma because he comes from a different part of the world where there is no technology and because he believes in natural ways of living. It turns out

that John has a big problem with the brave new world and how people live there. Will he be able to survive living there? Well, you will have to read the novel to find out. Brave New World is considered a classic in English literature, and it is one of the best novels I have ever read.

4. 1. Aldous Huxley. 2. satire. 3. sleep teaching. 4. (one character named) John the Savage. 5. John the Savage. 6. Brave New World. 7. the singular verb *is*. 8. *which* (antecedent: satire) and *that* (antecedent: a type of humor); no, *who* refers only to people.

My notes